

PRASANNA SCHOOL OF PUBLIC HEALTH, MAHE, *Manipal*

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"The Prasanna School of Public Health is unique as it is in an ecosystem where there is statistics, data science, public health and administration coming together. A student who comes for MSW comes out as an expert in a multi-domain area which is what is the need of the hour"

DR CHERIAN VARGHESE
Professor and Director, Prasanna School of Public Health

World Health Organization (WHO), lists various reasons why this is so. Foremost of these is the need to understand societal changes in a rapidly, and haphazardly, urbanising milieu, and an equally evolving workplace. An interesting trend of late, Varghese points out, is of employers preferring MSW graduates with a specialisation in HR Management over an MBA in HR, given that the former offers more insight into the dynamics of society and the human element. "Another major ingredient for MSW is research," he says, adding that MAHE incentivises research by supporting the costs of publishing journal articles. The MSW programme has had 75 publications, and the main areas of research include mental health, ageing and aged care, adolescent wellbeing, child protection, CSR, leadership, workplace wellness, urban mobility and social auditing.

The two-year MSW at PSPH offers specialisations in three areas—Medical and Psychiatric Social Work, Community Development, Human Resource Management and Industrial Relations, which students take up in their second year.

"The main thing we have focused on is making the learning experience student-centred where we use a lot of participatory pedagogies," says Teddy Andrews, head of the department of social work. "Secondly, we have tie-ups with local organisations such as non-profits, hospitals and industries." Thereby, experiential learning, he says, has been built into the curriculum, with students spending two days in a week in the field. The department has also developed a questionnaire to measure the care and support available for lonely older adults. "We also need to know what the rest of the world is doing," says Varghese, adding that most of the faculty at PSPH have received international training.

Given the key role of social sciences in tackling societal challenges, Varghese says the aim of the MSW programme is to prepare people for tomorrow. ■

**College showing highest improvement in scores in past five years*